the creation of Jio Star, are consolidating audiences and resources, enabling us to compete with global giants. On the other hand, there's a growing emphasis on hyperlocal content that speaks to the unique identities and aspirations of regional audiences.

This shift has catalysed a golden age for Indian storytelling, where regional voices are emerging as powerful drivers of change. The rise of regional cinema, with languages like Marathi, Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Kannada creating waves not just domestically but also globally, speaks volumes about the diversity and richness of our cultural fabric.

At its core, entertainment is about connection. It's about telling stories that move people, stories that celebrate who we are and who we aspire to be. Indian audiences today are more discerning than ever. As I've often said, "The audience can't be tricked." They demand authenticity, originality and narratives that resonate with their lives. And a story told with authenticity finds its legs to travel worldwide.

One of the most exciting trends shaping the future of entertainment is the synergy between traditional broadcast and digital platforms. Contrary to the belief that television is a diminishing medium, it remains robust and growing in India, bolstered by the expanding middle class, extensive internet coverage and fresh investments in diverse content. The recently announced Disney-Reliance merger, resulting in the creation of Jio Star, exemplifies the opportunities that lie in harnessing this convergence. By bridging the worlds of broadcast and streaming, we can cater to an even broader audience, combining the reach of traditional media with the depth and personalisation of digital platforms.

COLLABORATING WITH GLOBAL STUDIOS, **PARTICIPATING IN INTERNATIONAL FESTIVALS AND EXPANDING INTO NEW MARKETS** ARE CRITICAL STRATEGIES TO ELEVATE OUR INDUSTRY'S GLOBAL FOOTPRINT

Technological advancements are at the heart of this evolution. Technologies like Generative Artificial Intelligence (Gen AI) hold immense potential to create immersive experiences, democratise content creation and enhance storytelling. It is already empowering smaller production houses and independent creators to produce high-quality content with limited resources, levelling the playing field and intensifying competition. As a studio, we have started leveraging AI at different stages of the film's lifecycle and to great effect. It's a myth that technology will take away jobs and cause mayhem. In fact, it can create a much-needed disruption in the production value chain, breaking the so-called nexus of a handful of creative minds and throwing the industry wide open for new voices and entrants.

However, as we embrace these advancements, we must remain mindful of their purpose: technology should enhance the emotional impact of stories, not replace their soul. The heart of great storytelling lies in its ability to evoke genuine emotion and make viewers laugh, cry and reflect.

As we look to the global stage, Indian cinema is making its presence felt like never before. The success of films like *Laapataa Ladies*, which had been selected as India's official entry to the Oscars, underscores the universal appeal of our stories. Indian cinema is no

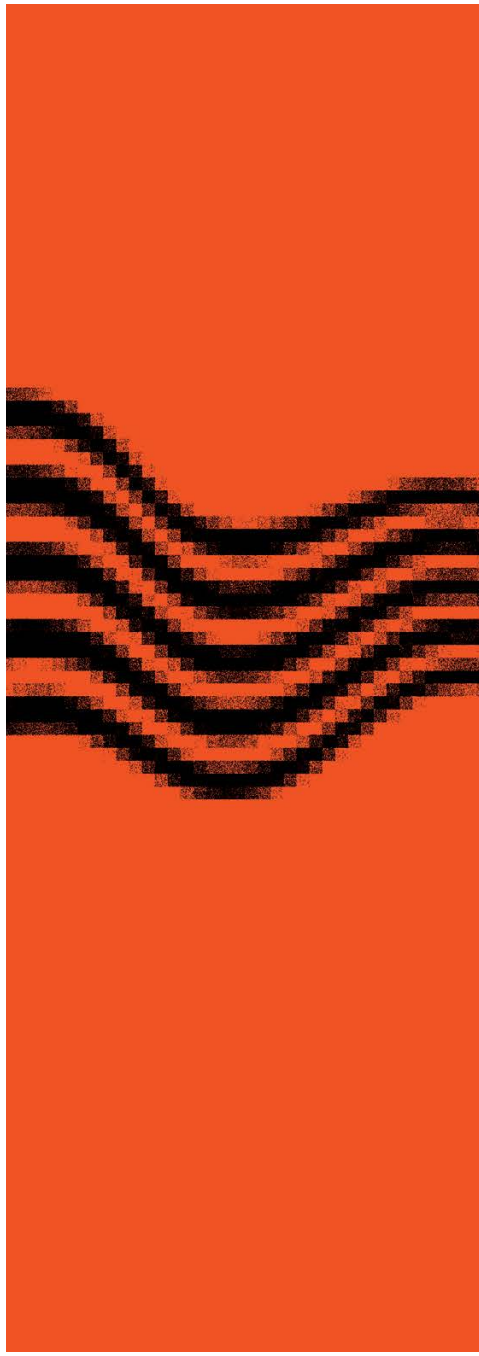


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